

Full boat of development proposed along Ohio River

By Bill Utterback butterback@timesonline.com | Posted: Sunday, August 21, 2011 10:45 pm

Along the Ohio River, as it travels three miles between the Interstate 79/Neville Island Bridge and the Sewickley Bridge, four recreational facilities are being imagined.

The projects -- three with river access and one at the river's side -- involve property in Coraopolis and Moon, Neville and Robinson townships. The sites could eventually be linked by an extended Montour Trail.

Allegheny County is moving forward with plans to develop a park for nontraditional team sports, while Moon is considering a riverfront park, Coraopolis is restoring its river launch and Robert Morris University is raising funds for a boathouse in Neville that may eventually serve university and community rowing operations.

"It's an exciting time," Coraopolis Council member Anthony Celeste said.

Montour Junction

Allegheny County recently announced it received a \$900,000 grant from the Richard King Mellon Foundation to advance its Montour Junction project, proposed in 2009.

The 78-acre park property sits between Route 51 and the river on land once owned by the Pittsburgh and Lake Erie Railroad. It includes 50 acres in Coraopolis and stretches to include portions of Moon and Robinson.

"Our goal is to make this dormant brownfield into a world-class recreational facility," Allegheny County Executive Dan Onorato said in a press release.

The county also revealed that it had completed a traffic study and received approval from the Pennsylvania Department of Environmental Protection. Both processes took more than two years. Earlier this year, Coraopolis agreed to change the parcel's zoning from industrial to public recreation.

The grant money will be used to develop Phase 1 of the Montour Junction project, which includes a featured field with seating and synthetic turf; three synthetic-turf practice fields; a community playground; and a bike/walking trail that will connect to the Montour Trail. The fields will be used for soccer, lacrosse and rugby.